The Small Towns off the Coast of Okhema

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The Small Towns off the Coast of Okhema

by MypersonalityisDepresion

Summary

Mydei happened upon the book by accident.

He was wandering in Marmoreal Market, alone missing his Deliver. When he entered a book store. Nothing really caught his eye, as his fingers dragged across the spines of books, until he found the book titled “The Small Towns off the Coast of Okhema”

He picked it up and started to flip through it idly, out of curiosity and nothing more.

Then he almost dropped it out of his hands.

“On the Gold Coast, wheat fields ripple as if the wind dipped its hand through pools of gold. In the center of these fields lay Aedes Elysiae, one of the smallest coastal towns…”

His Deliver’s Aedes Elysiae!

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Or 5 times Mydei read about Aedes Elysiae and the one time Phainon told him about it.


Notes

TRIGGER WARNINGS WITH SLIGHT SPOILERS (I don't know how to do the cool drop down thing)
–Mydei mentions trying to kill himself to get rid of his sickness quicker
–Mydei again mentions this latter in the section
—(If you still want to read this fic, but don’t want to read this skip the “On the history of Aedes Elysiae section and go to Stories from Aedes Elysiae)
–Mydei typical death in the beginning (he gets shot by an arrow)

This fic drove me insane

See the end of the work for more notes
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Mydei happened upon the book by accident.

He was wandering in Marmoreal Market.

He ventured through alleyways, to avoid the large crowds that typically gathered in the regular marketplace. Small shops lined this route. They sold neat wares and antiques, something his Deliverer would be excited about, if he were here with Mydei.

But Mydei knew that his Deliver is on a mission away from Okhema right now.

And Mydei refused to admit to himself that he was wandering down the ways Phainon would frequently walk.

So what if Castorice sent him a look whenever he forced her to do a training routine with him in place of Phainon, and so what if the triplets giggle whenever he found himself making the foods that Phainon typically likes.

They can think what they want.

He was walking down one of the alleys when he came upon a small shop. A book shop, one he never noticed before. It was nestled between two other shops. Outside were carts with books on them, and when Mydei peered inside he saw old tomes lining the walls. It smelled like that old book smell, the one where if you breathe in the wrong way dust would go up your nose. There were a few plants sitting in one corner of the room, and a few tables sat in the other with more books on top.

For the first time since his wandering started a shop caught his eye.

So, he did what his Deliver would do and entered.

At first nothing caught his eye. There was a lot in the store. The books ranged from novels to scientific theories to short stories meant to entertain children. He even saw books on Castrum Kremnos, impressive but nothing that Mydei didn't already know. It was a cute shop, but nothing interested him.

That was until he came across a book called "The Small Towns off the Coast of Okhema" Unlike the golden books that Mydei would find in the Library in Okhema, It was fraying at its edges. It was a brown book that had no fancy embroidery. Its texture was rough, and well used.

He picked it up and started to flip through it idly, out of curiosity and nothing more.

Then he almost dropped it out of his hands.

"*On the Gold Coast, wheat fields ripple as if the wind dipped its hand through pools of gold. In the center of these fields lay Aedes Elysiae, one of the smallest coastal towns…*"

Mydei stared blankly at the pages.

“Aedes Elysiae”

His Deliverer’s Aedes Elysiae?

Mydei didn’t think twice before rushing to the clerk’s counter to purchase the book.

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“**Aedes Elysiae Contents.**”

“*Aedes Elysiae is a town with a rich history, despite it being small. A peculiar but beautiful town dedicated to Oronynx despite being a farming town.*”

Each section was labeled as so, with a brief description about the section. Then it would go into detail about the town. The section about Aedes Elysiae had a few main sections: the dialect, the history, and the culture.

Of course, Mydei was interested in it all.

Phainon kept anything related to his home town close to his heart.

Anytime it came up, Phainon masterfully guided the conversation away from it towards something else, usually Castrum Kremnos if Mydei was nearby. Over the long years that Mydei knew him, he has only managed to get three things out of his mouth.

The first being the golden fields that surround the town. Phainon would recount days spent napping in the fields when he cut class. He would look wistful when describing them, clearly missing the calm days before his fate as a Chrysos Heir.

The second thing was the soft tides that hit the shore, and the smell of salt. Phainon told him once about when he would wake up early in the mornings, before the Dawn Device was the only light source in the world. How he would watch the light ripple over the ocean, with Aquili painting the sky in hues of red and purple.

He mentioned wanting to take Mydei there one day, after the Era Nova. A comment that Mydei held close to his heart.

The third was a prayer to Oronyx.

Mydei felt slightly guilty, reading about Phainon’s home town. He should let Phainon guide any conversation about the town at his own tempo, but something is drawing Mydei to the book.

And he has a feeling it’s from Minesta.

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“**On the Dialect of Aedes Elysiae**”

“*The dialect of Aedes Elysiae is closest in nature to Castrum Kremnos, though it holds a lot in nature to the accent of the City of Okhema. While Okhema typically uses shorter vowels and Castrum Kremnos typically cuts them out, people from Aedes Elysiae typically hold out their vowel sounds, in a drawl of sorts typical for small towns that rest on the countryside…*”

Mydei was proud of his accent, the accent of his people. It proved that through everything, he is still a Kremnoan. He enjoyed training with the Kremnoan people in the morning, hearing their resounding voices chanting out in unison, short and clipped, just like their nature. After all actions speak louder than words.

Meanwhile, the Triplets hardly noticed when theirs came out. Sometimes when Trianne gets too excited, and they start to speak incredibly fast, slurring their words together. Then Tribbie would come over and chide them for their fast speech…while they spoke just as fast to get their own point across, slurring and combining words as they talked. Eventually they would quiet down to listen to Trinnon, who would speak softly and quietly to them, talking about days long past through shortened phrases and combined words.

Their accent too reflects themself. How they kept their pace through their centuries of life, in order to never fall behind on the flame chase journey. They look towards the next light, keeping up and sometimes outpacing others.

In order to, as the triplets would say, look towards the next tomorrow.

Castorice’s accent was lighter than Mydei’s and the Triplet’s. It was slower, and sometimes some vowels sounded the same,she would pronounce words the same way, despite one word having an “e” in it and the other an “a.”

Mydei compared it to how she simply adores life, unable to touch it. Slowly she looks, appreciating everything around her, and in a darker way she equalizes her vowels just as death is supposed to equalize them all.

But Phainon…

Well, it was cute, the rare times Mydei got to hear Phainon’s accent slip through.

Phainon clearly worked hard to cut out any remnants of his own accent. A clear attempt to fit the mold of the perfect Deliver of Okhema. It takes a lot, and when Mydei says a lot, he means a lot, for even a hint of Phainon’s accent to slip through.

The first time he heard it he died.

Literally.

He bled out and died.

Phainon and him were sent out on a mission to an outskirt town that was infested by Titan-kin infected by the black tide.

The town was a small farmer town. Broken houses lined empty streets. Wood from broken roofs and doors litter the ground while dead trees lined a stone path road. It smelled like the afterburn of destruction. In the distance were wooden lined structures that looked like it supported some kind of bush, a clear sign that the town specialized in orchards.

What grew in the orchards? Well, now that's lost to history.

They were fighting side by side. Adrenaline rushed through Mydei's veins. His hands were slashing through the brittle sides of the Titankin. A gentle rhythm fell in place, one that allowed for Mydei to mindlessly slaughter. Golden blood flew through the air, as the sticky substance fell onto Mydei. In between his rhythm, he watched Phainon move, to keep an eye on his new acquaintance.

At this point in history, they barely knew each other as Mydei just arrived in Okhema with the detachment. A surface level trust formed between them. Mydei would have called it a bond between co-workers who shared the same goal. Friends on the surface, but nothing deeper.

Mydei was aware of this "perfect" Deliverer. Agleae's golden boy, and Okhema's pride. Devoted to the flame chase.

Phainon was trying to get closer to him, Mydei knew that. But, Mydei refused to let the dog of Agleae and Okhema get close to him. Mydei tolerated him for the sake of his people, to set a good example to them and to the city.

When Phainon offered to show him around the market, he accepted, he showed good faith. Set a good example for his people on how to act in Okhema when facing the Okhemens. Show them that despite their history of bloodshed against the city, they must be bigger and choose survival over glory. And if that meant following Agleae's golden boy around, so be it.

Phainon continued to slash through the Titainkin. Golden blood spurting everywhere, even onto his perfectly white coat. Like Mydei, it appeared that Phainon fell into a rhythm when he was fighting, keyed into the battle and nothing more around him.

He has to admit though, Phainon was a good fighter.

First he managed to last ten days and nights against Mydei, a feat not many can achieve. Secondly, Mydei was currently watching him as he fought his way through the Titankin. Sword hacking its way through, golden blood flowing. That's when he noticed Phainon getting blurry.

Which was odd, because he was perfectly in focus just a few seconds ago.

Phainon turned his head, his pretty silver hair swished over. He was looking Mydei's way, eyes wide, mouth agape in a faint yell that Mydei could barely hear over the sound of blood rushing..out? Looking down, Mydei saw the cause of his current issues.

A lone Archer managed to peirce through his heart.

The last thing he saw was Phainon cutting the last Archer down, and rushing straight at Mydei.

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The first thing Mydei noticed when he came back from the dead was something soft underneath his head, that smelled faintly like lemon, a very Phainon smell. The second thing Mydei noticed were hands on his chest right over his heart.

So naturally he grabbed them, only to be abruptly woken up by Phainon's screeching.

Mydei was looking up at a coatless Phainon, whose hands were covered in golden blood and resting over Mydei's heart. Phainon was as pale as a sheet, and he shook slightly. The blood on his hands was no doubt Mydei's own. Looking into his eyes, he saw tear tracks running down his soft pale, well paler than usual, face. The expression he wore was one of terror and shock, and Phainon opened his mouth only to let out a...

"Wuh thuh hell!"

An Arrow must have also hit Mydei's brain and his body has yet to stitch it back together.

What the Fuck.

Phainon continued to speak. He yelled about an arrow and Mydei's heart, while he flailed his bloodstained hands around. But all Mydei could think about was the way Phainon spoke.

His words were slightly slurred, and they blended together rapidly as he tried to figure out why Mydei was still alive. He was dropping endings off of words and the "r" mysteriously vanished out of others.

"You're alive!"

"Your voice?"

"HOW ARE YOU STILL ALIVE!"

"You have an accent???"

"My dear Mydeimos," Phainon started, his voice slow in a hypnotising drawl, his accent shone through in every word, "How the Fuck are you still alive."

He supposed that's when their relationship truly started. Instead of it being the Golden boy of Okhema chaperoning the Prince of the Kremnoian forces around Marmoreal Market, it became the boy who was originally from out of town, showing a fellow, confused, outsider around, out of good will and not of duty.

And just like how Mydei's own accent reflected his people, he could see how Phainon's reflected Aedes Elysiae…or how Mydei thought Aedes Elysiae was.

Slow, calm, peaceful.

Fields that rippled gold with the wind, like how Phainon's words rippled slowly as ichor coated words flowed from his lips. His accent was slow, often it drew out words. Still there was a sense of speed as Phainon dropped endings off of some of his words. Which was also like Phainon, who often let the day carry him along, helping whoever came to him quickly and efficiently.

And just like Aedes Elysiae, it quickly vanished.

Phainon was clearly shaken after the experience, unaware of Mydei's own immorality. However, after they began to grow closer. Close enough that sometimes a word would slip through or a sentence would be drawled out. Rare, incredibly rare, a once in a decade experience.

But those moments laid fondly in Mydei's heart, just like Phainon's description of Aedes Elysiae.

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"**On the History of Aedes Elysiae.**"

"*Aedes Elysiae is primarily a farming town. Their main export is wheat, and sometimes fish that they may catch. Each year the adults will head to the fields to plow and sew seeds, beginning what is their cycle. Afterwards they will pray to Oronyx to let time safeguard their harvest.*"

Mydei never thought Phainon was religious.

By all means, to the people the Chrysos Heirs were very religious. Venturing forward to claim the divinity from the titans on the basis of a prophecy. The way Aglaea spun the tale made it seem like they were doing this to honor the titans. Reclaiming the divinity from those who went mad, in order to continue their legacy.

Honestly they're just followers of a Prophecy.

Mydei's relationship with the Titan of Strife is…well it exists. Complicated in nature. Mydei knows he must be the one to inherit the Core Flame of Strife, despite how much he wished the opposite. Nikador is important to his people, thus they should be important to Mydei.

But Nikador never had an impact on him.

He's heard the stories of conquest led by Nikador. Kremnoian tales of glory and bloodshed. All a glorious and epic fate for a hero, but not a fate Mydei wants for his people. Nikador desired conquest and strife, while Mydei desired survival and preservation. Thus Mydei and Nikador could not be further apart.

Agleae was much in the same boat. Her and her Titan were drawn together by fate, once perhaps more similar in their nature. But as time passed, and Agleae's humanity left her, they
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drifted apart. Minesta devoted to a love of everything, Agleae's devotion solely to Okhema. And as the years go on, Mydei could barely tell if her devotion is still out of love.

Titans forbid look at Anaxagoras, Phainon's teacher.

Enough said, the blasphemous professor seeking the meaning behind the prophecy of Flame Chase.

So, Mydei was surprised to find Phainon over his bed mid prayer to Oronyx.

"What are you doing?" Mydei's voice was rougher than usual. A sickness was coursing through him, something he wasn't used to. Sweat covered his body, making his pajamas stick to his body. His head was fuzzy, and he had trouble recalling the previous few days.

The curtains in his room were closed shut, dulling the light from Kephale. The covers of his bed were drawn over himself. His side table held a water glass half full. Next to the glass was a note and a bottle of medicine from Hyacine.

"Since I'm taking care of you I thought why not pray." Phainon leaned over him, a gentle smile resting on his face. He was quieter than usual, probably suspecting Mydei of having a headache, which he would be correct.

"There would be no need for prayers if you simply let me die." He retorted. He aborted rolling his eyes, as it made his head worse.

Now Mydei remembered, the issue with the current situation was that he was sick.

Normally he would kill himself, quickly and efficiently. When he revived, his sickness would be gone. But Phainon found him, mid claw to his throat, and tackled him to the ground.

The worst part about it was that it made his headache worse when he hit his head on Phainon's shoulder.

Phainon frowned.

"No."

"Hks."

Phainon pulled up a chair that usually rested in the corner of Mydei's room. Sitting down, he started to fiddle with the bottle from Hyacine.

"It does you no good to just kill yourself when your sick."

"Being sick does me no good." Mydei was not used to it. There was no time to let his body rest when his people were on the move. As their Prince, he was meant to dedicate himself to his people, and that meant making sure he was in tip top shape. If he even felt an inkling of sickness… well you know the rest.

Phainon sent Mydei a glare. He forced opened up Mydei's weakened and cold hand and pushed a few pills onto it.

"I don't like it when you kill yourself."

Mydei tried not to let anything show on his face. A cool breeze rustled Mydei's hair as he tried to dig himself further into the blankets.

"I don't like it when you just throw your life away,"Phainon sighed and looked away towards the water glass,"and not just here when you're sick."

"Death does not have its grasp on me. It does nothing."

"Still. Death isn't just nothing." Phainon handed Mydei the glass of water.

Phainon opened and closed his mouth for a little bit. Debating on whether he should keep talking. His hair glimmered gold under soft rays that breached Mydei's closed curtain, while his eyes glimmered with sadness, before finally deciding on continuing. "I don't like it when you lay in its palm."

Jealous much…but some part of Mydei found he didn't mind.

But at the time, he didn't want to think about what part of him didn't mind.

Mydei shifted up, now too hot to stay under the blankets. Phainon helped him up with warm hands . "What were you praying earlier?"

"Oh…"

Mydei tilted his head.

"Aedes Elysiae was a town devoted to the Time Titan…"

Mydei swallowed the pills then nodded, allowing Phainon to guide the conversation.

Phainon looked towards the curtains, a sad look swept his face. He started to fiddle with the pill bottle in his hands, a typical Phainon habit Mydei always took notice of.

A section of his brain is devoted to the small habits Phainon partakes in.

He doesn't know when he started cataloging the little habits Phainon does, but he doesn't really want to think about it now, not when the room is soft, and Phainon is sharing a bit of his heart with Mydei.

Phainon stared in a corner. "In Aedes Elysiae.. We would often pray to Oronyx to safeguard the time it takes till harvest." Phainon's eyes looked soft and unguarded. It was clear to Mydei that all that occupied Phainon's mind was golden fields, soft winds, and people whose names now only exist in Phainon's mind.

“So, if someone got sick during the wait, we would pray to Oronyx to safeguard the time it takes for them to get better.” Phainon looked back at Mydei. Careful hesitance laid in his eyes.

It took a lot for Phainon to share parts of his home town. It lay raw and aching in his heart. It was a small town, yet it left such a big impact on a single person. Phainon always said that the destruction of his town changed him, for good and for bad. So knowing that Phainon trusted Mydei enough to share it…

“Will you teach me?” Mydei asked.

Phainon was shocked at first, eyes opening wide, the faint gimmer of Kehaple’s light shining through on them.

Then Phainon smiled. A smile entirely unlike his “Deliverer” smile. It was crooked and his teeth poked through in some spots. His eyes were crinkled in a way that was entirely Phainon and not the Deliverer and all Mydei could think about was how soft he looked, and how he wanted that smile to remain on his face for as long as possible. A light flush covered Phainon’s face.

Mydei felt his heart beat rapidly in the soft silence.

“Then clasp your hands and repeat after me.”

It was a nice time.

Of course, Mydei felt horrible at the time, and he absolutely never wants to sit through a sickness ever again. But with Phainon there, he didn’t mind it all that much. And with Phainon directly taking care of Mydei, that meant the Deliver was directly in the line of the sickness that ravaged Okhema at the time. Long story short, he got sick. And Mydei stood over his bed with clasped hands. Phainon lay down on his bed, wet cloth over his forehead, as Mydei recited a prayer.

Maybe Mydei will keep Phainon’s words in his mind when he falls sick again.

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“**Stories from Aedes Elysiae.**”

“*Aedes Elysiae has quite a few stories passed down through the generations that lived there. One story particularly caught my attention. But there is a bit of backstory to it. Wind chimes hang all over the town. And while not unusual for a regular town, it's particularly unusual due to the amount that is in Aedes Elysiae.*”

“*The residents of the town say that at night fairies will visit the town. They glide through the chimes ringing it as they go performing a dance. Moving along with the soft breeze.*”

When Phainon goes on missions, he often acts as free as a bird. He takes time just to float along the breeze. When Mydei goes on a mission with him, and it's quite often, Phainon often
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delays their walk back to Okhema. He often insisted on competitions to Mydei, and Mydei was never one to refuse a competition from Phainon.

At the time Mydei just chalked it up to a competitive spirit, and in part it was. But the other part…

They were running through a valley, neck in neck, competing on who would reach the end of the valley first. Green swirled around them as they rushed. A faint breeze blew against them, and the area smelled of faint grass. They were close to the end, it was just in reach.Then Phainon seemingly tripped on thin air.

The thing about Phainon was when he trips, he doesn't just take himself down. He took anything within his proximity down with him, like an overgrown dog dealing with their extended limbs.

Meaning Mydei was very quickly approaching the ground.

A loud thud resounded as they hit the ground.They rolled over each other and they disturbed the grass around them. The warriors were trying to get up before the other did, to continue the race and beat the other. Mydei's legs flew over Phainon trying to pin him to the ground. While Phainon flailed his hands everywhere trying to avoid Mydei. Heat flared on Mydei's face, as he felt those warm hands grab over his chest, trying to push him away.

They tossed and turned, their sprint long forgotten. Eventually Phainon won the struggle by sitting right on top of Mydei.

Phainon was smiling down at Mydei, his hair cascading down resting against his silver coat. Thanks to Agleae's weaving, no grass stains lay on it. Mydei could feel his hands, one resting on his neck, and the other enveloping Mydei's own crossed wrists above his head. Thighs bracketed his hips. Mydei felt his face get warmer and warmer, but he couldn't move. He was stuck as he stared into Phainon's gentle face, and warm smile, that seemed to light up his glowing silver hair.

No, the glow was coming from behind Phainon. Then it moved in front of Phainon, illuminating his face and hair. It was fireflies. They flew overhead. They illuminated their surroundings and bathed the two warriors in a soft gold.

"I think we disturbed the fireflies." Mydei said.

Phainon merely nodded his head, still staring at Mydei. One hand still rested against Mydei's neck, and the other bound his hands together. Mydei felt something in his stomach twist, clearly from the perceived loss and nothing else in particular.

So he tightened his legs, which still rested under Phainon, and pushed himself up and over Phainon. So, instead of Mydei being on the ground, now it was Phainon, with one hand still grasping Mydei's wrists, and the other moving to stabilize Mydei around his waist.

And Phainon was still staring…

They stayed like that, for a while longer. They stared at each other, with the low hum of the fireflies in the background. Mydei's wrist felt sore, and his back was in an uncomfortable position, but he couldn't find it in himself to look away.

"Pretty." Phainon broke the silence.

Mydei felt his face twitch, "Huh?"

Phainon flushed a golden-red, something that has been happening more often. Mydei ought to bully him to go to Hyacine to get it checked out. It would do them no good for the Deliverer to be sick.

Phainon opened and closed his mouth for a few seconds. "The fireflies."

"Ah"

Mydei wiggled his hands in Phainon's grip, and Phainon got the message. Phainon let his grip go, and Mydei rolled off of him, onto the grass still agitated by their rolling spar.

"I've never seen so many of them before." Phainon said, eyes reaching towards the night sky littered with the fireflies. Mydei has seen that look on his face before. It's the look of the Deliverer remembering a town.

Then out of nowhere Phainon's eyes lit up with an idea.

"We could dance like the fairies in Ades Elysiae!" Phainon giggled, jumping up out of the grass.

"What?" Mydei was confused, especially because he had no context here…

Phainon dusted himself off. Then he shuffled so he was in front of Mydei so he could hold out his hand. He had a gentle smile on his face and the wind tousled his hair.

Mydei found himself always going with the whim of Phainon. And regrettably, most of the time, he enjoyed the little games that Phainon would play to delay their return. So, Mydei cautiously took it, and Phainon lifted Mydei up.

He led him slowly, into less deep grass, where the fireflies buzzed. Their accompaniment was a soft breeze that rustled the grass around them, and the footsteps of the two warriors that dropped their mantle for a brief moment.

Kremnoans, to the surprise of Okhemens, do actually dance. Of course the meaning and reason why is completely different from the Okhemens. Dancing was just an extended form of fighting. To the Kremnoans, to learn to dance is to learn to manipulate your body. And to Manipulate your body is to prepare it for war and strife.

So Mydei was unfamiliar with the softness behind this dance.

Phainon slowly moved the hand not holding Mydei's to lightly circle his waist, bringing Mydei out of his thoughts. The air filled with the swell of the breeze. Meanwhile, the stars

glimmered overhead, as if watching their soft dance throughout the cold night.

“Is this ok?” Phainon asked, hushed.

Mydei nodded, voice not working. He felt both cold and hot at the same time as they moved. He lifted his hand to Phainon’s shoulder, and let it it rest lightly.

Phainon started his first movement, drawing them back ever so slowly in time with nature's music around them. He dramatically swirled Mydei around, giggling as they went, and surprising Mydei. Mydei will not admit he might have let out a small yelp. Then Phainon started to slowly sway with Mydei, and let the rhythm of the bugs and wind guide them.

Mydei could only look at Phainon.

Phainon could only look at Mydei.

Mydei moved his hand inward to rest right against the sun on Phainon’s neck. His touch was firm, and he unknowingly started to move his thumb against the point of the sun, right next to his choker. He watched as Phainon’s eyes slowly lowered, half lidded. Still they stared into his own.

Mydei wanted to tear off the choker, and leave his own mark right next to it.

The bugs illuminated their way, as they slowly made their dance across the field. The cold night air long forgotten. The grip on his waist grew stronger and bolder as it made its way behind Mydei to rest on his back, and Mydei shuddered.

The hand, right over his 10th thoracic vertebrae.

Phainon let go of Mydei’s back, just as quickly as it settled there, quickly Mydei let go of Phainon's hand, unwilling to let go of the man's neck, and grabbed Phainon’s other hand.

Mydei looked up, moving his back slightly to get that hand back on it. “Keep going.”

And Phainon obliged. He stretched out his fingers and rested his warm palm right on the spot that would stop Mydei from ever waking up.

Slowly they spun, and Mydei realized in that same moment that he fell in love.

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“**On the Culture of Aedes Elysiae.**”

“*There are many ways in Aedes Elysia for one to show their love. For platonic love, they share their food and enjoy company. Gift giving in another common way to show their love.*”

“*For romantic love, a simple confession will do; however, there are two special traditions for one to show their devotion. The first is the gifting of jewelry, commonly something that resembles the giver, often it’s something the giver made themself. This comes from the story of a soldier who had to leave the town, so they crafted their beloved one last gift.* ”
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Mydei should say he's surprised.

But honestly, it is just like his Deliver to do something like this, and never tell him what it meant.

Granted Mydei was in the same boat. Wanting something more, but unwilling to tell the other, out of fear of the prophecy, or out of fear of a reaction. Eventually it got to the point that Mydei was simply comfortable where he was at. So colour him surprised to know his Deliver already confessed to him… Before himself!

Mydei remembered the day Phainon gave him the armlet that he proudly wears.

He was training, when he got a message from Phainon. It was simple and straight to the point, a location and a request to meet him.

Entirely unlike his Deliverer.

So out of concern, Mydei rushed his cool down and quickly made his way to Phainon, who said he was outside of Chartonus' forge.

And there he was, talking to Chartonus, relief on his face and holding a small box.He was in his regular outfit and to a regular citizen, it would look normal.

But Mydei is not a regular citizen. Phainon's coat was slightly askew, as if he just put it on. Even his hair was slightly out of place. His face looked calm, but Mydei could tell that something was weighing on him and if it was someone other than Phainon, Mydei wouldn't have cared…

But it was Phainon.

And a little secret that Mydei had to sadly admit to himself at the time, is that he cared about Phainon.

"Deliverer."

Mydei watched as sparkles lit up in Phainon's eyes, and an imaginary tail wagged behind him. He started to fiddle with the box in his hands.He quickly said something to Chartonus before making the short walk to Mydei.

"Mydeimos!"

He stopped in front of Mydei. And looked down at Mydei. Something danced behind his eyes, that Mydei attributed to a mix of madness and hope. He looked slightly worse up close, bags sat under his eyes, and bandages lined his fingers.

"Won't you come with me?" Phainon asked.

“Why?” Mydei responded in a simple manner. He wanted to say “of course,” but he wasn’t going to speak that out loud. If Phainon needed Mydeimos to cut Aquili down, he would. If Phainon told Mydei to find the lost treasure of Phagosa, he would.

But he won't tell Phainon any of this, of how far he would follow the man, lest he get a big head.

“Please?” Phainon spoke softly, his voice and face laced with a quiet pleading. He shifted the box to tug on Mydei’s covered arm with his free hand. It was a funny sight knowing that Phainon is taller than him.

Mydei could see Phainon’s imaginary tail drooping.

And well, Mydei was always a sucker for cute things.

“Where?”

—

Phainon took him to a restaurant. It was slow at the time that they arrived. There were a few people around them, but not close enough to hear anything that they might discuss, which was a very good thing, because Phainon was very awkward today. Unusual for his silver tongued Deliver.

Phianon sat on his right, a half eaten salad in front of him, a typical nervous tick that Phainon has, that was entirely worrying Mydei. Meanwhile he was still eating his own chicken salad, that tasted a little too bland for his tastes.

Mydei watched Phainon carefully.

It was clear to Mydei that all of Phainon’s agitation stemmed from the box he held in his hands. Mydei wasn’t going to pry, instead he would let Phainon speak on his own terms, do the Deliverer a favor and let him think before he speaks for once in his life.

And Mydei didn’t have to wait for long.

“Mydeimos…” Phainon started, still fiddling with his box in his hands.

“Remember how we went on that mission and you broke your Armlet?” Phainon started passing the box from hand to hand. His eyes were set on the box, refusing to look at Mydei.

Mydei continued to eat. Slowly scooping up his meal. He does remember that mission. A rouge blade hit his old armlet in just the right way to cleanly snap it two. He remembered feeling sad about it at the moment, but ultimately moved past it. He could always buy another one, or have one commissioned from Chartonus.

“Yes.”

Phainon took a deep breath and passed over the box in his hands.

The crowd in the distance seemed to muffle when Mydei faced Phainon. Phainon looked at him like he won glorious battles and gave Phainon everything he would ever need. His posture leaned towards Mydei, all his concentration focused on Mydei, and Mydei found himself holding his breath.

All that mattered was Phainon and Mydeimos in this moment.

Mydei placed his spoon down and gently took the box from Phainon's hands.

He held it gently, and treated it with care as he slowly opened it.

Inside was an armlet. Gold swirled in intricate patterns that looped on itself. Cross hatches of gold further weaved through drawing his eyes to the middle of the piece, where a single intricate blue gem laid. It captured the attention of the eye, drawing your focus to the middle.

Honestly it reminded him more of Phainon than of himself.

…

Mydei desperately wanted to wear it.

"I thought, well you seemed to miss your armlet that you used to have. So I thought, why not get you a new one!" Phainon started to ramble, a golden red flushing over his face. Another nervous habit Mydei has cataloged in his head. If Mydei left him to his own devices Phainon would work himself into a hole of self doubt.

Mydei looked up and stared at Phainon, "Put it on me."

"Huh?" Phainon paused mid speech only to whip his head at Mydei.

"Do I need to repeat myself? Put it on me Phainon." He stared at Phainon, handing the box back to him. Phainon hesitated, before lifting his hands, to an awaiting Mydei.

The noise of the crowd vanished in the moment, lost to the two of them. Nothing in the world mattered in the moment. Mydei was not the Prince of the Kremnoians, and Phainon wasn't the Golden Deliver of Okhema. It was simply a Kremnoian and an Elysian, together as they shared a moment.

Mydei lifted his arm, and gently placed his hand in Phainon's arm.

He didn't dare to breathe, lest it shatter the moment.

Phainon's face was one of pure devotion, as he gently embraced Mydei's awaiting arm. Slowly smoothing the Armlet up Mydei's arm, caring to make sure it didn't pinch any skin. Phainon's silver hair glimmered, as he leaned closer to Mydei's arm, making sure it stayed firm in place. Only leaning slightly back to look into Mydei's eyes, looking for approval.

They stayed like that, neither willing to break eye contact.

Mydei was honestly an idiot for not noticing sooner.

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"**On the Culture of Aedes Elysiae.**"

"*The second way comes from the end of the story about the soldier and their beloved. The people said that two lovers, one from Castrum Kremnos and one from Aedes Elysiae, were dancing around each other, so painfully that even the strife-laced Nikador noticed. They said even Minesta was unable to help, at their wits end.* "

"*Then Nikador demanded the soldier to return to Kremnos. After years of service, the soldier returned to Aedes Elysiae. Unknowing what to do with themselves, they sat in the center of the community, recalling the years they spent there previously, and the one that they loved.*"

"*They closed their eyes, thinking of fond memories, when a soft spoon filled with bread and pudding breached their lips. Quickly opening their eyes, they looked up and saw the one that captured their heart, a smile upon their lips and longing in their eyes.*"

"*Thus to this day, if someone in Aedes Elysiae wanted to respond to a confession, they would make this bread pudding and sneakily get their other half to eat it.*"

"*Luckely, I managed to get the recipe from one of the villagers.*"

~~~~~

Phainon was tired.

He spent the past weeks held up in some fallen ruins of a temple on the border of Okhema's lands, managing forces and fighting back the black tide. No other Chrysos Heir to accompany him.

It was lonely.

Sure he had some of the soldiers to keep him company, but it wasn't his Chrysos Heirs. No Castorice to share short stories around a fire with, none of the giggles from the triplets to encourage him to keep going, and worst of all no Mydei.

His Mydeimos.

Phainon sighed, as he tried to relieve the tension in his shoulders.

Him and Mydei could have had so many competitions. It could have been how many Titankin could they kill, or how fast they could clear the areas of the ruins. Hell he would have even taken a stupid competition like how quickly could they finish their dinner.

Phainon dearly missed Mydei.

And the two weeks away only made his heart grow fonder.

He was just locked in with his memories of Mydei and all he means to Phainon. First their ten day fight got stuck in his head. Just thinking about the pure adrenaline and the rush he felt

as he fought his equal.

Then he started to think about the less known things, like how Mydei won't laugh at him if his accent slipped through. Instead Mydei would toss him a light look, one of fondness, that totally doesn't send Phainon's heart into overdrive, that causes Phainon to end up making a fool of himself because of it.

Or when Mydei stood over his bed, hands clasped in a prayer from a town that only exists in his memories. As he tenderly refilled the water on his table, and measured out the right amount of bitter medicine Hyacine gave him to make him feel better.

Mydei often went along with whatever Phainon cooked up at the time, whether that be a contest or dancing to the soft music of fireflies and a soft breeze. And Phainon loves Mydei, he loves him so much. His heart was full and ready to burst.

Eventually it got to the point where Phainon simply couldn't hold it in.

So he did the only thing he could do, without ruining what they had.

He fell back on the traditions that are only known to him now.

Well, honestly he made Mydei's armlet in a brief fit of madness one day. Unable to keep it all in, but unwilling to say anything at all. So he rushed to Chartonus and not only commissioned the piece, but asked Chartonus to guide him in making it. He probably looked like a mad man at the time. Hair scattered about, clothes a mess, early in the morning before most people, except the forges preparing for the day. He might have even had eyebags from the lack of sleep he got the night before.

And he might have put too much effort into designing the thing, and putting it together, taking up a lot of Chartonus' time, but in the moment it didn't really matter to Phainon. All that mattered was putting down his feelings into something for Mydei, and alleviating what he was feeling.

Though seeing Mydei wear the armlet did numbers to his own heart, both good and bad. Good, because it satiated a dark ugly part of Phainon that wanted to see Mydei only in his colours even if it was small. Bad, because Mydei was wearing something that in Aedes Elysiae would make them a couple and Phainon doesn't know if his heart could take that much.

Especially knowing that they aren't dating…

Phainon sighed again, making his way through Marmoreal Market, crowds bustled around and started to thin out due to the time of day.

He knew he was being a coward, and Mydei would no doubt wring his neck for the route he took. However, he will stand by his decision, on the sole fact that… Well he doesn't have a good reason for it, and honestly he should probably tell the golden mained man about the armlet, but every time he resolves himself to do it he ends up finding Mydei and falling deeper in love.

Which should be impossible. But Mydei was his impossible man.

So yes, Phainon was tired, and part of it was in fact from the mission. The other part was him worrying over the armlet and figuring out if he should do anything.

So, he sat down in the center of the market, leaning against the wall.

Would it really hurt if he closed his eyes for a bit?

So he did, relaxing against the wall in the center of the market, waiting for the one who has captured his heart, who shall never know how deep his affections run.

Waiting for the golden hair that shimmers under Kephale's light, a soft smirk that would be resting on his face when he saw how tired Phainon was. Phainon can imagine exactly what Mydei would say to him in that rough voice of his, that does numbers to his heart.

In the distance he could hear the metallic greaves of footsteps making their way towards him. No doubt Mydei himself.

Phainon was about to taunt Mydei when he felt it, something small and sweet forcing its way into his mouth.

He rapidly opened his eyes only to see Mydei, who held a bowl in one hand and an arm extended with what was a spoon in the other. On his tongue lay a soft sweet bread that only exists in his memories, combined with a pudding that means something that he's pretty sure Mydei doesn't know about.

"Myhie"

Mydie scowled, "Don't talk with your mouth full."

Phainon pouted with the spoon still in his mouth. His heart rapidly beat in his chest. Entirely the fault of the man in front of him. Unaware of what this meant to Phainon.

Unaware of how long Phainon had imagined a moment like this to occur. How many long nights Phainon spent curled in bed, thinking of how Mydei could have responded to his love both good and bad, if only Mydeimos himself knew about it. This… hurts. More than Phainon could have ever thought.

The crowds continue to walk around them, unknowing of the current mix of love and sadness that is rushing through Phainon, because of Mydei's actions.

Said man was slowly pulling the spoon out of Phainon's mouth.

Phainon could barely look Mydei in the eyes. He felt a slight flush run up his face, so he chickened out, a common theme when it comes to the combination of his love and Mydei, and turned to look towards a store front.

"trying a new rec-" Phainon tried to muster a teasing tone that was quickly shushed when Mydei grabbed his chin with his gauntlet hand, making sure Phainon could see his face. For

some reason, Mydei's ears were a soft golden pink. As he fiddled with the bread pudding in his hands, scooping up more.

"You know Phainon, normally when people profess their love, they just say it outright."

Mydei gently placed another spoonful into his currently agape mouth.

"It makes things a lot simpler."

"What." Phainon drawled, his accent slightly coming through. He could feel golden-red rushing onto his face, no, a golden-red that covered his entire body. A mix of embarrassment and hope.

Mydei frowned. Lowering his clawed hand from Phainon's face. "Were you really going to keep this to yourself?"

Phainon mirrored Mydei's face, the red still…everywhere. He attempted to take the spoon from Mydei's hands.

"What are you talking about..." His accent is on full display now as Mydei's grip remained strong. In fact he just ignored Phainon's attempts and scooped up more of the sweet desert and put it into his mouth.

"I didn't take you as a coward, Phainon." Mydei sighed and looked around. The crowd hardly noticed them, and if they did, they assumed it was another competition between the two. "Do you really want to have this conversation in public, where you will be a bumbling mess?"

Indignation coursed through Phainon's veins, "Who says I'll be a bumbling mess?"

Mydei raised an eyebrow, and leaned over Phainon. He raised his gauntlet hand back up to Phainon's face. Phainon braced for impact, preparing to maneuver his face out of the way.

He was promptly bamboozeled, by Mydei, who drew his clawed hand lightly under his chin. It was like he was scratching a dog, and it forced Phainon to stare directly at him. A slightly mocking smile passed over his lips, while his eyes shone with glee, as he cooed at Phainon's bright red face.

"Won't you come with me?"

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"**Aedes Elysiae, According to Phainon of Aedes Elysiae.**"

"So your genius idea was to confess to me, in a moment of madness and yearning?"

Phainon was sitting on Mydei's bed, faced away from the man himself. Red has yet to leave his face as he slowly nodded his head.

Regrettably, Mydei was right about him being a bumbling mess.
~~~~~

The curtains were drawn open, to let the light flow in. Meanwhile the chair that Phainon got well acquainted with, when Mydei was sick, was moved back to its proper spot against a wall. Mydei himself was standing in front of Phainon, as he leaned against the wall, because as soon as Phainon resigned himself to his fate, Mydei pushed him to the bed and demanded answers.

Mydei snorted.

“And you were never going to do anything about it.” Phainon wanted to bury himself into a hole in the ground. At this rate he would run open arms into Castorice and give her a nice warm hug. She can have his books he got from the professor. Meanwhile Agleae is sadly going to have to find another Chrysos heir to take on the mantle of Kephale, they know that he doesn't deserve it.

Mydei stared at him, completely unaware of the rampant thoughts running through his head.

Then the thought struck his mind, way too late for his personal preference, but better late than never. “How did you know about it?”

Mydei slightly shifted, “I read about it.”

Phainon tilted his head like a dog.

Mydei crossed the room to a bookcase that he recently got, one that Phainon gifted to him after Mydei’s bout of sickness. After he realized that Mydei had no bookcase of his own. They spent the night trying to figure out how to build it, putting pieces in wrong places, throwing scraps at each other. It was a fun night.

“I was walking around the market when I came across this book.” Mydei held it out to Phainon for him to cautiously take. It was booked marked to two pages. The first was the start of a certain chapter that made golden fields flow in his brain, as he remembered a soft breeze.

There were small notes in the margins, written in the chicken scratch that could only be Mydei’s handwriting. They were small things like what to get Phainon as a gift that was common in Ades Elysiae, or what foods Ades Elysiae might have had.

Achingly, they were all about Phainon himself, and what he might miss about Ades Elysiae.

Phainon has never wanted Mydei more.

Then he turned the pages to the second bookmark, which was about the jewelry and how to respond to it. Mydei watched Phainon put the pieces together in his mind.

“You gave me this armlet out of love did you not? Then you have my response.”

Phainon looked up so quickly he felt his neck jolt in pain. Mydei’s face was flushed a wonderful golden-red, as he stared into Phainon’s own eyes. Mydei’s arms were crossed, highlighting the flush that traveled down to his chest, and Phainon unabashedly followed it down with his eyes.

Phainon himself was not unaffected. He could feel heat and a flush that traveled over his cheeks.

Then Phainon perked up, an idea forming in his mind.

“You know Mydei, there's another tradition in Ades Elysiae that the book never mentioned.”

Mydei narrowed his eyes, “What is it.”

“When a couple got together there was often one thing they would do.”

Mydei nodded his head, flushing even redder at the mention of being a couple.

“What would they do?”

Phainon gave him his best smile, the one that crinkled a little too much at the edges and was a little too crooked for Phainon’s tastes, but Mydei mentioned once that he would rather see this smile than his perfected smile. And Phainon would do anything for Mydei.

Phainon continued to tilt his head a little bit, and placed a finger to his lips. A few light taps, a signal.

And Mydei’s eyes widened in understanding, slowly moving forward into Phainon's space. Somehow getting impossibly redder. He leaned down. His eyes level with Phainon, the light softly hit them both as Phainon finished Mydei’s movement for him.

Their lips connected and Phainon smiled in the kiss, letting Mydei lead the way. Mydei thought that if Phainon had a tail, it would be rapidly hitting the bed, as a pleased noise broke through. From Phainon or Mydei, we’ll never know.

And Phainon of Ades Elysiae thought it was perfect.

And Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos thought it was perfect.

And they finished the story of the soldier who returned home, missing their beloved hoping that they thought of them as they were gone as they looked into the jewelry they made. Wanting more but never reaching out, only for their beloved to return their love in force.

End Notes

IN COUNTRY PHAINON WE BELIEVE IN!

When I mentioned this fic drove me insane, I genuinely mean it. I could not stop writing it, it consumed my every waking moment. At work? Thinking about this premise. With friends? Thinking about this premise

All this started out with me just wanting Phainon to have an accent. Then it spiraled out of control.

Lowkey though, this is the longest fic I have ever sat down and continually written, and I'm proud of myself. Did I nick-pick my way, a bit, but I'm still quite proud of myself. And it was cool looking back at the other things I have written and seeing the progress and improvement in my writing.

Have a good day! And (lowkey I'm so sleep deprived and I'm blanking on the word) Building(?) critiques? The helpful critiques thing is appreciated, and I love reading any comments.

Edit 1: I just edited the tags a little and I'm including the link to my tumbler because my friend dragged me through the sea of souls so I could make one

MypersonalityisDepresion (https://www.tumblr.com/mypersonalityisdepresion)

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!